

The Almonte Gazette

Founded 1867

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New year brings new hopes

If last week was a time for looking back on the year that was, perhaps today is a time for gazing forward to see what we can look forward to — or hope to look forward to — in 1994.

From the town's standpoint, the coming year will feature a municipal election. We don't think many people would argue this council, featuring several first-time councillors, has done a good job on the whole. Still, rumor has it some may not be returning for another kick at the can.

Anyone out there with political aspirations might want to keep an eye on the paper as the fall election date draws nearer. The last election in 1991 featured 11 candidates for the six councillor positions. May we be so fortunate this time.

With any luck, 1994 will bring good news as far as the town's lagoons are concerned. Consultants have been working to gain approval from the Ministry of Environment to increase the capacity of Almonte's sewage facility. Their report is now with the ministry. Its approval could lead to a lifting of the virtual freeze on development first slapped on the town in the mid-1980s.

We'd like to see the town take more of a leadership role in the new year as far as recycling matters are concerned.

With the search for a county dump site now on hold, Almonte could find itself in the same boat as other municipalities before too long — having to ship its garbage to a Laidlaw site near Carp. Its own dump won't last forever. Why not take steps to ensure it remains in business as long as possible by initiating local programs, such as a community compost?

On the sports front, we hope the arena holds up until financing can be secured for its much-needed overhaul. While the town has given its backing to the near \$1 million project, it will probably be years before the work can be done.

A fundraising group has been formed and will be initiating programs and events to extract monies at the local level with an eye to gaining a provincial grant down the road.

Outside town limits, we hope 1994 will bring about some semblance of sanity to the situation in Pakenham Township.

The ongoing feud within the municipality surrounding two or three contentious issues has brought unwelcomed publicity to the municipality.

As the bearer of most of this bad news, the Gazette has taken a beating from the few who have been put in a bad light. In particular our reporter has faced much verbal abuse because he dared voice an opinion on a particular topic — funding for the recreation association.

Most recently a petty, unwarranted — and unattributed — report was published and circulated throughout the municipality as part of the group's December newsletter. The report took several cheap shots at the newspaper about two straight-forward stories on the R.A.'s recent needs assessment.

We see the assessment study — the result of 18 months of hard work — as an excellent first step from which to plan the future of recreation in the township. Our stories reflected this positive feeling through the comments of those interviewed.

This, clearly, was not good enough for some on the R.A. board.

Good study or not, they took it upon themselves to poison what was a true community project. Frankly, all the 'correction' did was make the board look silly. What a shame.

It's this sort of childishness from those who are running the show that brings the recreation program into question.

If community leaders are so concerned their township is being made the laughing stock of the county, they need look no further than themselves. If they're looking for respect, they're going about it the wrong way.

Perhaps the New Year will bring a new light to the situation. But we have our doubts.

— R.C.

Opinion



Heading out can be a difficult operation

To Coin A Phrase

By Ryland Coyne

well forget trying to stick to any sort of time schedule. Telling someone you'll be somewhere at a particular time is fruitless. If you're lucky you'll be there within an hour of the specified time.

Rule two — planning review.

Once the plan is down on paper, go over it in advance to make sure nothing's been omitted.

An important aspect is time. Approximating how long each task will take is key to arriving at your destination on time.

My wife Sheila and I use the simple yet proven 10 minutes = one hour calculations. Anything that used to take 10 minutes, surely will now take you one hour — at least.

Taking this into account, an excursion

to Grannie and Grandpa's house begins days if not weeks in advance.

Rule three — put plan into action without distractions.

Don't have the television on, don't listen to the radio, don't even answer the phone — if it means it could throw you off.

First thing for us is the clothing. How many outfits does baby need? What would Grannie like to see him wearing? Does he even have a special Christmas outfit? Does he need a Christmas outfit? Do we like the cutesy-wutesy Christmas outfit he was given for the occasion?

Then, there are the essentials. Does he have enough clean diapers? (Key question). Have we packed his powder, lotion, burp pads, blankets, socks, undershirts, diaper wipes, wash cloths, hair

brush...the list goes on and on.

On the day of the move, of course, there are the intangibles, those little things that throw a wrench into the best laid plans. Besides getting him dressed and prepared for the trip — all of which is included in the plans, it's those little surprises you forgot that can throw everything out of whack.

Like that last minute diaper change to keep baby happy, a last second temper tantrum (by baby, although parent is known to join in as well) to ensure stress level reaches maximum capacity, or a feeding that takes just a little longer than expected.

By the time you've taken all the steps necessary to get baby ready, you realize you've forgotten just about everything you were supposed to do for yourselves.

With practice, this routine does get better until the parental units begin to work like a well-oiled machine. That is until that second bundle of joy comes along...but that's for another time, far, far in the future.

Letters

"Almonte" sign has some faults

To the editor:

With reference to the article in the Dec. 29 Gazette, concerning the town's new sign, I would like to make the following comments:

1. You say that "Mervin Tosh does not agree" it was a step forward. Not so! Placing a good town sign at the main entrance to Almonte is a good step forward and long overdue.

2. A reader of this article may wonder why I am critical of the sign when the picture in the Gazette looks good. That picture is a close-up picture and I have no difficulty with it because, at short range, the sign is very good.

My criticism relates to one's ability to read the sign from farther away. At that point the letters tend to run together and become blurred.

In addition, I find the bar in the letter "A" to be so thin that the letter does not look like an "A". My opinion is shared by most of the people I have talked to, and some of them know much more about signs than I do.

3. I am quoted as saying that "it is too far off the road for people to notice." What I said was that it should have not been located in the highway ditch but rather on higher ground so people could see it more easily.

Actually, I feel that the sign should not be located on the highway but back from the highway.

4. If one is driving at 30 miles per hour, one is moving at 44 feet per second. Even at that speed one has only three seconds to read the sign.

5. I am surprised that the Ontario Ministry of Transportation would approve the erection of such a sign (to be landscaped with big stone blocks) on their property.

6. Please note the visibility of the Carleton Place sign at the junction of Highways 7 and 15 as seen from a distance.

7. Consider also the gold and green sign at the Canadian Golf Club between Carleton Place and Stittsville. It is capable of being read from a distance.

8. While I like gold lettering, I must say that in bright sunshine it is difficult to read the sign.

9. I might add that not all drivers have

young eyes.

10. Perhaps there could have been savings by having the lettering only on one side. Both sides seem excessive and unnecessary.

In summary, I think the sign is beautiful but is inappropriate as a highway sign, and its location is wrong.

In order to test public opinion in this matter, I invite the Almonte Gazette to carry out a survey through its newspaper by asking people if they like or dislike the sign and why.

Mervin Tosh

World turned blind eye at GATT talks

To the editor:

I write about the outcome of the recent GATT trade negotiations affecting agriculture, and especially the future of Canada's supply management marketing systems.

First, I regret that the world did not and would not accept the vigorous arguments advanced by Canada for a strengthened and clarified Article XI in the GATT. We have long believed that a new Article XI, i.e. an internationally sanctioned system of border controls on imported products — was the most direct means by which to safeguard our unique marketing systems. This Canadian position was put forward over seven long years of GATT negotiations.

For most of that period, we had important international allies on our side: the European Community (EC), Japan, Korea, Switzerland, Norway and Israel. But the United States was always unalterably opposed.

Eighteen months ago, the EC joined the U.S. in arguing against Canada. Later, Norway, Israel and then Switzerland fell silent. This past October, Japan abandoned the cause for Article XI. Korea did the same in early December.

Canada was then left isolated — the only nation in the world that continued to battle for a strengthened and clarified Article XI. We continued to pursue the fight all alone, to the closing hours of the GATT negotiations. It is regrettable that the world unanimously rejected the Canadian position.

When our new government took office on Nov. 4 (with barely six weeks to go

before the Dec. 15 GATT deadline) we rapidly immersed ourselves in the trade issue.

In our election platform we had identified a conclusion of the GATT talks as critically important to Canada's economic position overall, but we also undertook to work aggressively for a strengthened and clarified Article XI, recognizing the importance of agriculture as a base industry.

We carried our message to the EC, the U.S., the Swiss, the Japanese, the Koreans, the Australians, the Cairns Group of Nations and the Director-General of the GATT. We enhanced our delegations in Brussels and Geneva with the addition of Ministers, Deputy Ministers, other senior officials and Members of Parliament.

I personally went to the bargaining table on three separate occasions, as did our Trade Minister, Roy MacLaren. The Prime Minister personally put our views to the President of the United States.

We hammered hard on all fronts, quite literally day and night, in the limited time our new government had available. But when the crunch came in the final votes, no other nation was prepared to support us to strengthen and clarify Article XI. Among 116 nations, Canada stood alone.

Fortunately, we were not caught flat-footed and unprepared at the end. Recognizing the direction in which the world was headed (toward "comprehensive tariffication" as a replacement for border controls), we went to work exploring the mechanisms that could be available to Canada under a tariff regime to maintain a domestic environment within which our marketing systems could still survive.

It would have been imprudent and irresponsible of government not to examine all possible options in the clear light of where the rest of the world was determined to go. So we did our homework to be fully prepared for the final GATT outcome.

In the end, we achieved a very strong tariff shelter for Canada's supply-managed sector. We also instituted limited access to the Canadian market for imported products — at or very near the minimum allowable under the new GATT rules.

These provisions, to come into effect in

1995 through 2001, together with other factors, such as the value of the Canadian dollar (which favors exports over imports) and the high quality of Canadian products, should sustain a domestic atmosphere in Canada within which our dairy, egg and poultry industries can be successful.

It is now up to us domestically to determine how we want our marketing systems to function for the future.

If the provinces, the supply management agencies, farmers and farm organizations are prepared to work constructively and cooperatively with the federal government within the new tariffication structures, we can expect to do well. We can shape the system we want to have for Canada. It's up to us to do it.

A previous Liberal government "invented" the unique and successful supply management system we have known in this country for the past 25 years — in the context of the trading rules prevailing in the world at the time.

It is now our responsibility to adapt those systems to continue to thrive and prosper in new world circumstances.

Those circumstances (the new GATT) may not be our preference. But with goodwill and self confidence, we need not fear the future.

While change is always unsettling, we must see the way ahead as an opportunity, not a problem, and make sure we take maximum advantage of that opportunity in the interests of Canadian agriculture.

For more information on GATT please call 1-800-668-1266.

Sincerely,
Ralph Goodale
Minister of Agriculture

Notify the Gazette at least one full day before your event.

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